



Wounded Allied soldiers are carried through the jungle by New Guineans. The harsh environment was as deadly an enemy as the Japanese.

ON JANUARY 20, 1942, SS GENERAL REINHARD HEYDRICH (1904–1942) chaired a conference at Wannsee, a suburb of Berlin. The purpose of the meeting was to brief German civil servants and foreign ministry officials on plans to systematically **deport Jews** en masse from every country in Europe. The Jews were to be transported to camps—chiefly in Poland—from which, it was made clear, none would return.

Meanwhile, a Japanese tide of conquest flowed across Southeast Asia. **The fall of Singapore**, a major British base that was surrendered to the Japanese

in February after token resistance, was a blow to the prestige of the British Empire. About 80,000 British, Australian, and Indian troops were taken prisoner.

Determined resistance by American and Filipino soldiers on the Bataan peninsula in the **Philippines** ended in April. Large numbers of the troops died as prisoners of the Japanese on the brutal **Bataan Death March**—a 62-mile (100-km) trek that was forced upon the malnourished and disease-ridden men.

As the Japanese advance swept over Dutch-ruled Indonesia and British-ruled Burma, Australians

worried that their country might be next. An **attack** by Japanese naval aircraft on the **port of Darwin** in Northern Australia in February caused over 500 casualties, and Japanese midget submarines penetrated Sydney Harbor at the start of June. In a sharp change of attitude, Australia began to look on the US, rather than Britain, as its chief military ally.

Amid intense anti-Japanese feeling, in February President Roosevelt signed **Executive Order 9066**, which allowed Japanese Americans living in the western United States to be deported to **internment camps**. About 120,000 ethnic Japanese were interned during the war.

As the United States geared up for total war, the **fight back against Japan** began. The naval battles in the Coral Sea in May and at Midway in June were duels between aircraft carriers, fought without the Japanese and American fleets coming within sight of each other. The **Coral Sea** encounter brought neither side decisive advantage, but **Midway** was a disaster for the Japanese Navy, which lost four aircraft carriers to American dive-bombers and torpedo aircraft.

The American victory at Midway was a turning point, but far from decisive in itself. When **American forces landed on Guadalcanal** in the Solomon Islands in August, the Japanese responded with ferocious determination, landing their own troops to counterattack and initiating a series of naval

“ I CAME OUT OF BATAAN AND I SHALL RETURN. ”

General Douglas MacArthur, US commanding officer, after his escape to Australia following defeat in Bataan, March 20, 1942

battles in which both sides suffered heavy losses. In **New Guinea**, **Australian troops** played a leading role in fighting in hostile jungle terrain.

In **India**, the British faced a political as well as a military challenge. With Japanese troops threatening an invasion from Burma, in August Mohandas Gandhi (1869–1948) and other National Congress leaders launched the **Quit India**

Movement, demanding full independence. Their campaign of civil disobedience was ruthlessly repressed by the British authorities, and more than 100,000 Indians were arrested, including Gandhi. Some Indian nationalists joined **Subhas Chandra Bose's Indian National Army**, which fought alongside the Japanese, but far more fought for Britain: around 2.5 million Indians volunteered for the British army.



THE HOLOCAUST

The Nazis murdered people from many groups, including Slavs, homosexuals, and gypsies, but their treatment of the Jews was without parallel. By 1942 they had embarked upon the total extermination of European Jews. To achieve this “final solution,” the Nazis transported Jews to specially built camps equipped with gas chambers. Most were killed within hours of arrival, but some were kept alive and used as slave labor. About 6 million Jews were murdered, two-thirds of Europe's Jewish population.



Nazi death camps

The Germans built death camps, mostly in occupied Poland, expressly for the killing of Jews. There were many other concentration camps in which tens of thousands died.

KEY

• Nazi extermination camp

